rock edict will have been left in no doubt that the message of the emperor was Buddhist-inspired because of the specificity with which the connection is made at the outset. In his compilation *Asokan Sites and Artefacts* the scholar Harry Falk puts this succinctly: ‘reduced to its essence it seems to propose that everyone become a Buddhist layman, develop zeal and thus mingle with the gods.’[27] However, in some of his other edicts the message is less specifically Buddhist and more broad based. This is so in Minor Rock Edict II which, along with the first edict, is found in many places in the Karnataka–Andhra region. While elucidating in this edict what he wanted his subjects to observe as part of the morality that he was propagating, the earlier clarity of connection with Buddhist virtue is missing. Rather, the listing suggests a sort of universal morality that no religious faith in India was likely to have any quarrel with. The broad-based nature of its ethic seems one that would have appealed to all sections of the populace. The key elements of its Brahmagiri version are:

> Obedience must be rendered to mother and father, likewise to elders; firmness (of compassion) must be shown towards animals; the truth must be spoken; these same moral virtues must be practised.
>
> In the same way the pupil must show reverence to the master, and one must behave in a suitable manner towards relatives.
>
> This is an ancient rule, and this conduces to long life.[28]

These various virtues have a universal rather than specifically Buddhist resonance. In reiterating them Ashoka also invokes ancient law or tradition (‘porana pakiti’) and does not take credit, as he did in his first message, for initiating a mission. The other striking thing about it, says the historian Patrick Olivelle, is that this enumeration is marked by a ‘silence on social vices or crimes, such as theft, murder, adultery, and other sexual offenses’ which were matters of major concern to the state.[29] Possibly, Ashoka considered his mission ‘to be something far more personal and “religious”—the development of character, virtue, and spiritual growth—